



S PRA DAS

THE CRUSHER: Arjun (left) shatters Manmohan's dreams

the ministry says.

Another controversial proposal—salary differentials within the universities in favour of better performing teachers—has also been rejected as its legal sanctity is in question. Former NKC member Pratab Bhanu Mehta blames the “promotion schemes” introduced in late 1970s for the dramatic politicisation of university life and the poor quality of teaching. “Under this scheme, university promotions were considered analogous to civil-service promotions, in that one ought to be entitled to promotion if one had demonstrated minimal competence,” says Mehta.

Both NKC and the ministry agree that government should dedicate more finances to higher education. Recently, the National Development Council approved the Eleventh Plan outlay of Rs 84,943 crore for the Department of Higher Education as against the last Plan’s approved outlay of Rs 9,500 crore. NKC has also recommended the setting up of 1,500 universities that would enable India to attain a gross enrolment ratio of at least 15 per cent by 2015. At present, the country has nearly 400 universities, including 24 Central, about 100 deemed, 228 state and private universities. The ministry supports the idea of improving the gross enrolment ratio, but wonders how NKC arrived at the figure of 1,500 universities. “The Commission has failed to touch base with the ground realities,” says the official.

The controversy assumes importance in the context of thousands of students seeking admission in universities and the spiralling demand for fresh graduates to meet the needs of a new economy. In the politicalscape, it has left the prime minister in a doubly-odd position of taking on Left-wing feelings with the Congress. ■

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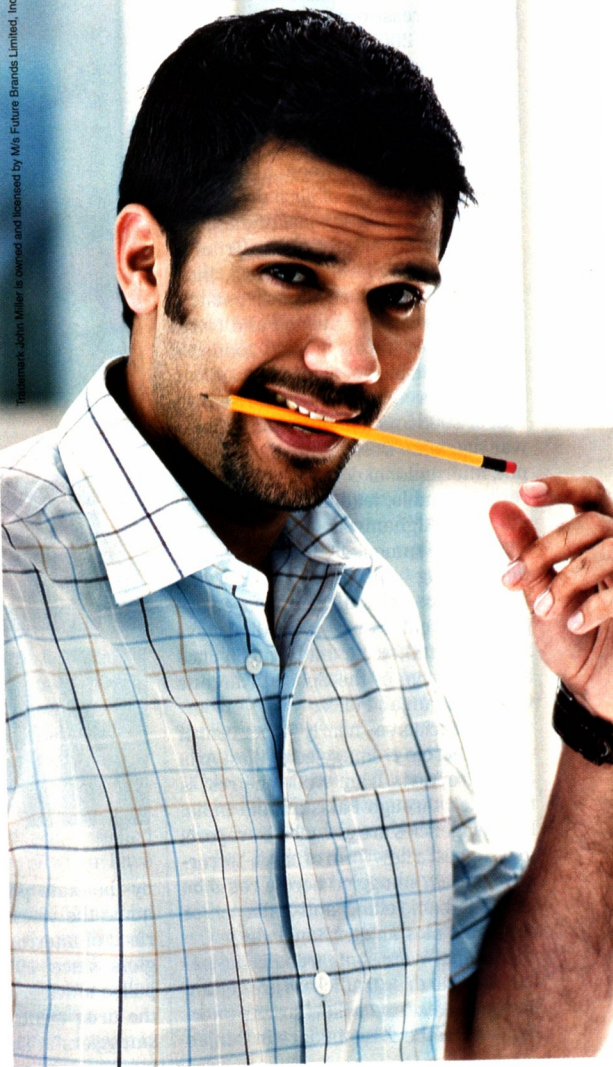
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